

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

ASE_Benin_2022-23_3-month report_(1)

Fellowship Organization

African School of Economics (ASE)

Fellowship City

Abomey-Calavi

Fellowship Country

Benin

Fellowship Start Date

06/20/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

06/21/2023

What is your fellowship title/role?

Lead Lecturer in English / Assistant of Academic affairs

What are your primary responsibilities?

Design and teach curriculum for first-year English classes for undergraduate students, academic and business English for first-year masters students, and GRE, TOEFL, and personal statement writing for pre-doctoral fellows

- Edits and proofreads academic and internal documents, including faculty articles for publication, work-study contracts, grant proposals, miscellaneous reports, and student theses and dissertations

- Provides bilingual student assistance (French/English) at the academic affairs office.

- Maintains and catalogs detailed records for Master's students from admission to graduation

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Somewhat

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

informal meetings with supervisors, brief overlap with former PiAf fellow

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**Describe a representative day at work.**

On teaching days, I usually have 1-2 classes which are two hours each. On days I don't teach, my schedule is flexible, and I decide how I want to organize my tasks.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

30

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

I assembled a Master's level business and academic communication course curriculum, which was non-existent previously for this class.

I am helping to re-design organizational processes in the academic affairs office.

What is your organization's work culture like?**What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.**

I share my office with a researcher; my office is also on the same floor as the president and my two direct supervisors. The office is a small room with a couch, two desks, and AC.

To whom do you report?

I report to International Relations Manager and Clementina Alamou, Academic Affairs Manager.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

somewhat

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

- 1) reaching a professional working proficiency in French (C1) by the end of the year, being able to function effectively in meetings and virtually all work situations
- 2) improve my teaching and communication abilities in the intercultural space
- 3) perfect my ability to manage my time (work, school, personal projects, social life, hobbies, etc.)

Do you receive adequate direction/support to perform your fellowship responsibilities?

Please provide more information on your response above.

I am also taking a French course and the Cambridge Diploma in TESOL, both online, in order to support my growth in delivering quality teaching and work. These online courses can take between 20 and 30 extra hours a week combined (meaning I can work about 60 hours total in one week), making it difficult to manage time. I have gotten much better over the past month in getting everything organized.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

No, but it has been discussed

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

I feel prepared in the sense that I have previous experience related to my job as well as having lived in the region before. I also am resourceful and know how to fill in knowledge and experience gaps over time. Finally, I am currently a graduate-level student of teaching, which has helped me to improve my teaching quality this year.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I flew United from Chicago to Cotonou with a layover in Brussels. In total, the trip cost around 800USD for a one-way flight. I found my tickets through one of my credit card sites because I was able to gain a huge discount (over 60%) through mileage points and deals. I have not booked my return flight yet because I don't know where I'll be going next.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

90- day tourist visa

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

online

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

yes

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

between 100 and 150 USD

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

I paid myself.

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

If yes, please explain further

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

The process to get the online visa is tricky if you don't have a credit/debit card which supports 3DS 2.0 (this security level is used frequently in Europe). I went through 8 different cards before

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

I already had my Yellow Fever vaccination previously. I was not required to show any vaccination to Benin, since all COVID-19 screening requirements from the Beninese government were lifted a few days before my flight.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

My arrival was fine. A driver from ASE picked me up from the airport and brought me to campus. Because I arrived on the weekend, I had to organize a lot of the necessary errands with the driver the next day (i.e. getting a SIM, finding a grocery store, finding a nearby ATM).

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Housing is provided by ASE.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Somewhat Urban (Suburban)

Please describe your living environment

We live in the middle of a slightly suburban neighborhood. There are several good restaurants and grocery stores near us, and we're within walking distance of a hospital, a gym, some hotel pools, tennis courts, and markets.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

A mototaxi generally costs between 1 and 2 USD to get into the center of Cotonou. I tend to hire a private driver, who charges around 15 USD round trip to do errands and shopping in Cotonou. I only take vehicles on the weekend because most things I need are so close by.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

N/A

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

The rainy season is now ending. There are two main seasons- rainy and dry.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

Work clothes can range from business casual to professional here. I tend to have a variety of formality throughout the week.

How have you been spending your free time?

I've started learning traditional Beninese music with a local NGO, and I'm also involved with music activities at a local jazz bar and a school in Togo. I will be performing in a piano festival in December. Aside from that, I've also gone out during the weekends, and spend my downtime working out, blogging, reading, or learning languages.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

It really helps to have an American roommate on the same program. We've also been able to branch out into different circles as well by honing in our individual interests and talents.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

Yes. I have not felt unsafe around this area.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I don't travel alone at night.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

N/A

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

N/A

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

Because my time management is getting better, I'm able to now focus more on these original goals. For example, I am more cognizant now of the time I dedicate to French study because as an ESOL teacher, I am always in environments which demand I speak English. So in some ways, I feel a bit disappointed having come to a French-speaking country when I mostly just speak in English.

I've also been good at forming local relationships and friendships through my extra-curricular activities.

As for learning more about African development and society, this has come with time and reading here and there.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

As far as living arrangements go, the guards are not too attentive at night and close the gate around 11 PM. This means we have to tell them whenever we are going out and coming back late, which is less than ideal for the spontaneous night out. As far as work goes, there are sometimes holes in communication which can arise, as well as plans and arrangements being finalized more last minute than I would prefer (e.g. delaying the start of the entire school year by a week when it is already September, or being told I need to teach an intensive GRE class with only a week's notice).

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

No

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I feel very comfortable in Benin because I processed a lot of my previous shock last year when I was living in Côte d'Ivoire. That's not to say that I still don't experience discomfort from time to time; however, I have just gotten used to things that used to bother me, and I've certainly become more flexible.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

I was surprised by how chill my experience in this country has been compared to my past two previous experiences on the continent. I don't get harassed as much on the street, and people have generally been quite kind to me. Perhaps this change is because of the character of this country or because I've gotten used to a lot of things.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

I find it challenging to manage time, mostly because I've been doing so much lately. It can sometimes be lonely trying to accomplish so much this year, but I do have a good support system, and I feel fulfilled when I make progress in my goals and dreams.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

- 1) Washing machines for laundry
- 2) accessibility to certain international foods and cuisines
- 3) Easy access to acoustic keyboard instruments (piano and organ) and Western classical music in general

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

- 1) Fresh produce and seafood everywhere
- 2) Rich tradition of Voodoo and other cultures specific to this region
- 3) the openness of local people

How is your stipend being paid?

monthly in USD to paypal

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

PayPal

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

no

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$40.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$70.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$200.00	\$0.00	\$50.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$70.00	\$20.00	\$0.00	380.00
Specify "Other"					
0					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

The orientation covered a lot of information in a short time, so I needed a lot of time to process. I'm also not sure I'm using all the resources offered as best as I can, and a lot of it is because I often forget that the files in the DropBox exist. I think it's important to cover all the information (and I'm glad PiAf has provided so many resources), but of course, nothing can fully prepare you for an international experience abroad.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

Tips on applying to visas. Country/regional-specific cultural things to look out for or be aware of.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

Not sure, but I'll think about it.